6 Questions That Reveal Why Users Abandon Software

(Even When the Feature Is Perfect)

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Why These Questions Work

Most founders ask users: “How do you like the software?”

That question produces polite, incomplete answers. The Mom Test teaches us that people lie to be nice. They say “I would definitely use that” or “I usually do it this way.” But future promises are fantasy. Past behavior is truth.

These 6 questions never mention the software. They force the user to tell a concrete story about a specific time in the past. That is where the real friction lives.

The 6 Questions (Mom Test Refined)

1. ***"Walk me through exactly how you currently handle [the core task] from start to finish — what do you do first, then next?"***

   Why it works: Forces a process story about their actual life, not an opinion about your tool.

2. ***"Tell me about the last time that process slowed down or broke. What happened?"***
   Why it works: "Tell me about the last time" is the strongest Mom Test phrase. It anchors the conversation in a specific, real event instead of a generic "it's sometimes frustrating."

3. ***"When that happened, who got involved and what did you have to do to fix it?"***

   Why it works: Reveals the hidden risk, blame, and political friction. This is where "shadow workflows" are born.

4. ***"What have you already tried to change or fix in this process before?"***

   Why it works: This replaces the old hypothetical "what would you change?" This asks about past actions. If they have tried to fix it, they care about the problem. If they haven't tried anything, it's not a real pain point.

5. ***"What tools or workarounds do you use today to get this done? What made you choose them?"***

   Why it works: Replaces the hypothetical "where would a new tool fit?" This reveals their actual current behavior. If they are using a messy Excel sheet, you know exactly what your software is competing against.

6. ***"Tell me about the last time you stopped using a tool or changed your process. What triggered that decision?"***

   Why it works: Replaces the hypothetical "what would have to be true to stop?" This asks about a real past switch. It shows exactly what threshold of friction or value is required to make them change their habits.

How to Use Them (The Rules)

- Never mention the software first. Let them bring it up.
- Deflect compliments. If they say “The tool is great,” say: “Thanks, but walk me through the last time you used it for a real task.” Compliments are meaningless.
- Anchor fluff. If they say “I usually just…” or “I would probably…”, pull them back: “When was the last time you actually did that?”
- Don’t defend the product. Just say, “Tell me more about that.”
- Talk less than 20% of the time. Silence is a powerful tool.

Simple Note-Taking Template

Reuse this page for every interview.

Name: _____ ***Date:*** _____

The specific event they described: _____

Question 1:

Question 2:

Question 3:

Question 4:

Question 5:

Question 6:

Key friction I heard:

What would actually make them switch:

How to Analyze the Answers

You have the answers. Now what?

A single interview is an anecdote. 2 to 3 interviews is a pattern. Here is how to turn their words into a fix:

1. Look for repetition.

If 3 out of 5 users mention the same workaround (e.g., “I still keep notes in a Google Doc”), that is not a user problem. That is a product problem.

2. Separate “Tool Issues” from “Trust Issues.”

If they say “I don’t use the AI summary,” ask why. If it’s wrong, that’s a tool issue. If they say “I double-check it anyway,” that’s a trust issue. Those require completely different fixes.

3. Rank by revenue.

Which friction point is causing the most users to cancel? Fix that one first.

The 6 questions give you the diagnosis. This analysis gives you the prescription.

Next Step

Running these interviews yourself is hard. Users will tell you what you want to hear, not what they actually do.

If you want me to run the first 3 interviews for you — so you see the method applied to your own customers — I am offering a limited number of Free 3-Customer Workflow Diagnostics this month.

You get the interviews, the notes, and a short findings summary showing you the exact patterns. No cost. Just honest feedback in return.

Message me if you'd like one of the spots.

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